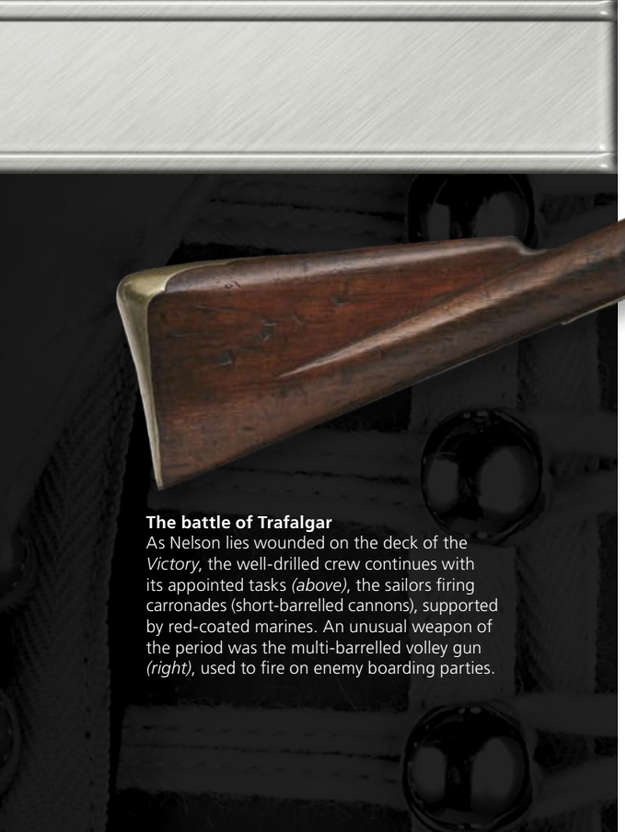


The battle of Trafalgar
As Nelson lies wounded on the deck of the *Victory,* the well-drilled crew continues with its appointed tasks *(above),* the sailors firing carronades (short-barrelled cannons), supported by red-coated marines. An unusual weapon of the period was the multi-barrelled volley gun *(right),* used to fire on enemy boarding parties.



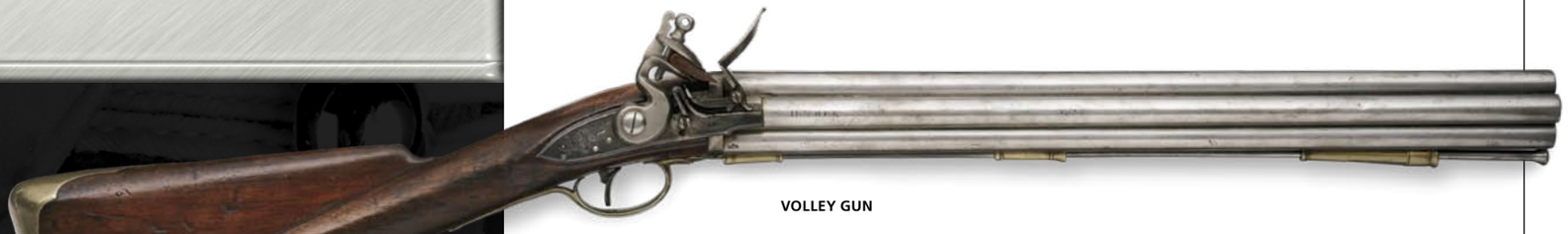
During Britain's wars against France between 1793 and 1815, the Royal Navy was outstandingly successful, scoring a series of major victories against equal or superior enemy forces. Its performances in battle were the product of a well-established system for nurturing seamanship and fighting skills at all levels from ordinary sailor upwards. At the same time, it must be admitted that the sailors, many of whom were "pressed" into service against their will, led a notoriously hard life, subject to draconian discipline.

Horatio Nelson, Britain's most famous admiral, began his naval career in 1771 at the age of 12, joining a ship captained by his maternal uncle. In this there was nothing exceptional. The officer class of the Royal Navy was mostly composed of the sons of respectable families – Nelson's father was a vicar – who had joined the service at least by the age of 14. They would have found a place through the influence of some relative or patron, or through a personal connection with a ship's captain. Although the hazards of ship-going life were severe, the navy offered a tempting career. As a midshipman the boy would learn the complex business of operating a warship, including the intricacies of navigation, and hopefully pass the exam for promotion to lieutenant after six years afloat. If he had the right patronage, or sufficiently impressed his superiors, he might be a post-captain with his own ship by the time he was 21, assured that if he survived long enough he would one day become an admiral by simple right of seniority. There was the chance not only of promotion but also, in time of war, of making one's fortune, for the admiralty paid prize money to the officers and crew of ships that captured enemy vessels. A captain who had the luck to take a number of heavily laden enemy merchantmen could become a rich man.

In peacetime, most of the lower ranks of the navy also joined the service at an early age. Children from the poorest strata of society – some saved from the streets by the charitable Maritime Society – became ship's boys at the age of 10 or 11. They did the lowliest jobs on board, from acting as servants for the officers to looking after the animals that were carried on voyages as a source of fresh food. Gradually they would develop the muscles and the skills to be sailors. They would learn to move nimbly barefoot on the pitching deck and in the rigging, and acquire the broad-shouldered, barrel-chested physique of a sailor, the product of years of heavy lifting and pulling on ropes. Such long-term volunteers formed the core of the navy.

THE NAVY AT WAR

In wartime, however, the number of sailors expanded rapidly – from 45,000 men at the start of the French Revolutionary War in 1793, for example, to 120,000 in 1799. Such numbers could not be supplied without the use of the infamous press gangs. The Impress Service scoured ports for experienced seamen – for example, men serving on merchant ships or river boats – and "pressed" them into the king's service. Men were also pressed at sea, a warship stopping a merchantman and forcibly taking the pick of her crew. Press gangs were highly unpopular and at times their methods were little better than kidnapping, but they provided a practical method of rapid selective conscription. The Quota System, introduced in 1805, was worse. Every local authority was ordered to supply a certain number of men to the navy; to fill their quota, they usually ended up by emptying the prisons, thus manning ships with petty criminals who were landsmen and often carriers of typhus.



VOLLEY GUN